FROM THE FLOOR UP · PLAYBOOK 01

The Front-End Offer *Designer*

Seven decisions to design the offer that gets cold customers to actually say yes — and a working framework for any local business.

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SERIES

HMYLB · Part 1

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WHY THIS WORKS

Local businesses need two offers, not one.

The reason most local marketing money disappears is that strangers are being asked to buy the biggest offer first.

Most local owners sell a single offer. The core thing they do — the long engagement, the annual contract, the full project, the ongoing care, the membership. Then they market that offer to people who have never heard of them before, and the math doesn't work. Most strangers don't buy a $2,500 annual gym membership when they're just hearing about your business through a Google search, they don't sign an annual HVAC maintenance contract from a flyer in their mailbox, and they don't commit to a 12-month patient plan from a dentist they haven't met.

A front-end offer is a low-friction, time-bounded first step designed for one job, which is turning a stranger into a customer. It's not the big offer or the money offer. It's the slice of your core service the audience can say yes to right now, before they fully trust you.

THE MATH THAT USUALLY CONVINCES AN OWNER TO BUILD ONE

- 100 cold leads see your core offer → 2 convert (if you're lucky)
- 100 cold leads see your front-end offer → 15 to 25 convert
- Of those 15 to 25 new customers, 40 to 60 percent ascend to the core offer within 90 days
- Same lead pool. 5 to 10 times more core customers, faster.

ONE REAL EXAMPLE, FROM JCF

- JCF ran two types of FEO: 21-day and 28-day programs (price-friction kind) and Weight-Loss Challenges, 6 to 8 weeks at $280 to $500 (value-stacked kind).
- Both ascended into the JCF annual membership at multiples of what cold outreach to the membership ever did.

THE SEVEN DECISIONS

Build your working FEO.

Answer each one with as much specificity as you can. Vague answers produce vague offers. Specific answers produce offers that convert.

DECISION 01

Who

The exact audience the offer is built for. Not "anyone in my city."

The person who you'd love ten more of. Specific enough that you'd recognize them if they walked into your business tomorrow.

My front-end offer is for:

EXAMPLES

- **Restaurant:** Couples in [neighborhood] looking for a date-night ritual, ages 30 to 55, who go out 2 to 4 times a month.
- **HVAC:** Homeowners in [zip codes] whose system is 8 to 15 years old and who want to avoid a summer emergency.

TRAP

Defining the audience as "anyone who needs my service." Too broad, the offer won't land.

DECISION 02

Outcome

The specific result the customer walks away with after using the front-end offer.

Concrete. Tangible. Something they can describe to a friend in one sentence.

After this offer, the customer will walk away with:

EXAMPLES

- **Dentist:** A clean mouth, a whitening boost, and a written care recommendation.
- **Custom cabinet shop:** An in-home consult, a digital sketch of their kitchen, and a written ballpark for the project.

TRAP

Promising a vague outcome ("better marketing," "improved health"). Specific outcomes convert. Vague outcomes don't.

DECISION 03

Time Window

How fast the customer gets the outcome.

Open-ended timelines feel risky. A defined window creates urgency and confidence.

The customer gets the outcome within ______ days/weeks of booking:

EXAMPLES

- **Chiropractor:** 7 days (initial assessment within a week of booking).
- **Contractor:** 14 days (consult + design plan delivered within two weeks).

TRAP

No defined window. Open-ended timelines feel risky to the buyer and the offer stops converting.

DECISION 04

Price

The friction-clearing number, by one of two paths, plus a transaction-time upsell that works alongside either.

Friction-clearing doesn't have to mean cheap. There are two paths, and both work depending on your audience. There's also a third lever that runs alongside both.

Price: $ ______

Path A — Low absolute price

- $29, $49, $99 are common entry points
- Small dollar, small decision. A "no-spouse-call" decision for the audience.
- Best for high-volume, broad-reach audiences
- Filters out tire-kickers without scaring anyone off

Path B — Higher price with overwhelming value

- $280 to $500+ are common entry points
- The cost-to-value ratio should be obvious in the first sentence of the offer
- Best for niche, high-intent audiences who already know what this work normally costs
- JCF Weight-Loss Challenges (6 to 8 weeks at $280 to $500) ran this path — nutrition program, group accountability, pre/post fitness evaluations, the workouts JCF was known for. The price felt small relative to what the customer was getting.

The transaction-time upsell (works alongside either path)

- Even when the FEO itself isn't profitable on the way in, the transaction is a chance to build margin.
- **Restaurant:** $59 Couples Tasting + $35 wine-and-dessert package upsold when guests are seated.
- **HVAC:** $99 tune-up + written "while we're here" list of small fixes priced for same-day approval.
- **Chiropractor:** $49 assessment + 3-pack of adjustments offered at the end of the appointment.
- Design the FEO to clear the friction at the door, and design the transaction to carry the margin.

TRAP

Pricing in the middle. A number too high to feel like a small decision and too low to signal premium value. That middle is where most FEOs go to die.

DECISION 05

Deliverable

The slice of your core service that fits inside the front-end.

A real preview of the core service, not a tangent. The customer leaves with a clear sense of what working with you for real looks like.

The deliverable is:

EXAMPLES

- **Real estate agent:** 30-minute market analysis call + a written 1-page report.
- **Restaurant:** A 3-course tasting menu for two on a quiet Tuesday evening.

TRAP

Building a deliverable that's unrelated to the core service. A free dessert leads to "I want another free dessert," not to a regular customer.

DECISION 06

Deadline

The response date that creates urgency.

The deadline does most of the closing work. "I should look into that someday" becomes "I need to call them this week."

Customers must respond/book by:

EXAMPLES

- "Book by [date] for the [season/cohort] slot."
- "Limited to the first 20 customers this month."
- "Available through May 30, then it's gone."

TRAP

Leaving the door open forever. Evergreen offers stop converting after the first push.

DECISION 07

Bridge

The natural step that moves the customer from the front-end into the core offer.

The bridge should be built into the front-end delivery itself, not improvised at the end.

The bridge to my core offer is:

EXAMPLES

- **HVAC:** At the end of the tune-up, the technician hands over the written system report and offers the annual maintenance contract on the spot.
- **Dentist:** At the end of the new-patient appointment, the patient is scheduled for their next 6-month cleaning before they leave.

TRAP

No bridge built in. The customer finishes the front-end and never hears from you again. Lost revenue.

WORKED EXAMPLES BY BUCKET

Six fully filled-in FEOs.

One example per major local-business bucket. Use these as templates, not as the answer. Your version needs to be specific to your audience.

BUCKET / VERTICAL	FRONT-END OFFER	BRIDGE TO CORE
Food & Beverage *Restaurant*	$59 Couples Tasting for two on a slow Tuesday. 3 courses, 75 minutes, paired wines available.	Birthday-club membership + private-event inquiry handed over with the check.
Trades & Build *Custom cabinets*	$149 Space Optimization Audit. We assess the space in person and deliver a 3D sketch within 14 days.	Signed scope of work + 25% deposit at the kitchen table.
Home Services *HVAC*	$99 seasonal system tune-up with a written report. Same-day appointment within 7 days of booking.	$400 annual maintenance contract offered at the end of the visit. Replacement system pipeline starts here.
Wellness & Health *Dentist*	$99 new-patient exam + cleaning + whitening. Scheduled within 14 days.	Next 6-month cleaning booked before they leave. Major work flagged in the written care plan.
Personal Services *Salon*	$59 first-time consultation + cut. 60 minutes with the senior stylist.	Color appointment booked + product purchase at the chair.
Professional Services *Real estate agent*	Free market analysis + 1-page written buyer/seller plan. Delivered within 7 days.	Listing or buyer engagement agreement signed at the close of the meeting.

THE PRICING MATH

Profitability is a design choice, not a yes/no.

THE COLD-TO-CORE CONVERSION PROBLEM

- 100 cold leads see your core offer → 2 convert (2%)
- Average customer lifetime value at core: $X
- Total revenue from 100 cold leads: 2 × $X

THE FEO-LED CONVERSION

- 100 cold leads see your FEO → 20 convert (20%)
- Of those 20, 50% ascend to your core offer within 90 days → 10 new core customers
- 5 to 6x more core customers from the same lead pool

THE TRANSACTION-TIME UPSELL LAYER

- Restaurant: $59 Couples Tasting + $35 wine-and-dessert upsell = $94 ticket with margin built in.
- HVAC: $99 tune-up + $300 same-day repair = $399 ticket with margin built in.
- Chiropractor: $49 assessment + $200 3-pack of adjustments = $249 ticket with margin built in.
- Designed properly, the FEO + transaction upsell pays for itself before the core ascension even starts.

DARIS'S JCF MATH, A REAL EXAMPLE

- Weight-Loss Challenges (6 to 8 weeks at $280 to $500). Value-stacked FEO that was profitable on its own at scale.
- 21-Day and 28-Day Programs (lower-priced FEO). Designed to give first-timers a low-cost test drive. Less profitable on their own, ascended into the JCF annual membership at high rates.
- Both flavors fed the same core offer (the JCF annual membership), and the business ran on the combination of FEO type, transaction-time upsells, and core ascension.

The principle. The FEO's primary job is conversion. Profitability is a design choice with three levers — the FEO price itself (Path A or B), the upsell at the moment of transaction, and the ascension into the core offer over time. The strongest businesses design for all three.

PRE-LAUNCH CHECKLIST

Before the FEO ships.

Confirm every box before you spend a dollar driving traffic to it.

- [ ] Audience defined in one specific sentence (not "anyone who needs my service")
- [ ] Outcome named in one sentence (specific, concrete, tangible)
- [ ] Time window set (a number of days or weeks)
- [ ] Price decided (low enough to clear friction OR high enough to signal premium value, not in the middle)
- [ ] Deliverable scoped (a real slice of the core, not a tangent)
- [ ] Deadline mapped on the calendar (a real date, not "ongoing")
- [ ] Bridge to core defined (the next step is built into the delivery, not improvised)
- [ ] Transaction-time upsell designed (don't leave the margin lever on the table)
- [ ] Tracking sheet built (so you know what's converting and at what rate)
- [ ] Team or partner briefed (so the bridge to core actually happens)
- [ ] First two weeks of marketing planned (which channels will drive traffic — see Issues 013 through 017)

COMMON TRAPS

Five traps that kill FEOs.

1. **Building a front-end too unrelated to the core.** Attracts the wrong customer. Free dessert leads to dessert hunters, not regulars.
2. **Forgetting the transaction-time upsell.** The FEO does the conversion work at the door, and the upsell at the moment of transaction is often where the margin lives. Build the upsell into the offer design from the start, not as an afterthought.
3. **No deadline.** Evergreen offers stop converting. The deadline is the urgency mechanism.

4. **Selling the core inside the front-end delivery.** Feels like a bait-and-switch. Build the bridge as a natural next step, not a sales pitch.
5. **Building the FEO before defining the audience.** Without the audit work from Issue 011, the offer hits no one.